

must be taken into account in teaching and that education must begin “where children are at.” Unfortunately, these ideas are often overlooked when it comes to cultural and linguistic differences. The fact that Yahaira León, whose case study appears at the end of this chapter, was fluent in two languages was rarely viewed as anything but a liability by most of her teachers. But if we are serious about providing all students with educational equity, then students’ cultures and identities need to be seen not as a burden, a problem, or even a challenge, but rather as assets on which to build.

Begin reading here

Defining Culture

Before we can ask schools to change in order to teach all students, we need to understand the differences that students bring with them to school. Culture is one of these differences, and we define it as follows: *Culture consists of the values, traditions, worldview, and social and political relationships created, shared, and transformed by a group of people bound together by a common history, geographic location, language, social class, religion, or other shared identity.* Culture includes not only tangibles such as foods, holidays, dress, and artistic expression, but also less tangible manifestations such as communication style, attitudes, values, and family relationships. These features of culture are more difficult to pinpoint, but doing so is necessary if we want to understand how student learning may be affected.

Power is implicated in culture as well. That is, members of the dominant group in a society traditionally think of dominant cultural values as “normal,” while they view the values of subordinated groups as deviant or perhaps even wrong. The difference in perception is due more to the power of each of these groups than to any inherent goodness or rightness in the values themselves. For instance, U.S. mainstream culture stresses the necessity for youngsters to become independent at an early age, whereas other cultures emphasize interdependence as a major value. Neither of these values is innately right or wrong; each has developed as a result of the group’s history, experiences, and needs. However, people with a U.S. mainstream frame of reference may view as abnormal, or at the very least curious, the interdependent relationships of Latino children and parents, for instance. They may characterize Latino children as overly dependent, too attached to their parents and siblings, and needing more attention than other children. For their part, Latino families may view U.S. mainstream culture as strange and cold for its insistence on independence at what they consider too young an age. The difference in these perceptions is that the values of Latinos do not carry the same weight, status, or power as those of the dominant group.

In this text, we are concerned primarily with the *sociocultural* and *sociopolitical* dimensions of identity, rather than with individual psychological identity formation. Thus, we focus on issues such as *power, institutional arrangements in schools, and the impact of ideology on culture* as well as *students’ lived realities and experiences in families and communities*. This is not to dismiss the importance of individual identity development. On the contrary, teachers should understand how children develop their social and cultural selves and how this process interacts with issues of race, ethnicity, gender, and other variables. The work of scholars such as A. Wade Boykin, Beverly Daniel Tatum, Gary Howard, and others focuses specifically on such matters. All teachers should become familiar with these theories as well as the sociocultural and sociopolitical perspectives underlying this text.⁵

We are always on shaky ground when considering cultural differences. The danger of considering culture lies in overgeneralizing its effects. Overgeneralizations can lead to gross stereotypes, which in turn may lead to erroneous conclusions concerning entire groups of people, not to mention the abilities and intelligence of individual students. We have all seen some of the more disastrous consequences of overgeneralizations: rigid checklists of cultural traits of different

ethnic groups, the mandate to use certain pedagogical strategies with students of particular backgrounds, and treatises on supposedly “indisputable” student behaviors. Culture, in such instances, is treated as a *product* rather than a *process*, and it is viewed as unchanging and unchangeable. Viewing culture in this way can also lead to *essentializing* culture—that is, ascribing particular immutable characteristics to it. This may result in thinking of culture as inherent in individuals and groups. Kris Gutierrez and Barbara Rogoff describe it as believing that individuals and groups are “carriers of culture—an assumption that creates problems, especially as research on cultural styles of ethnic (or racial) groups is applied in schools.” They suggest using instead a cultural-historical approach stemming from the theories of Lev Vygotsky that recognizes the histories and valued practices of cultural groups. Rather than thinking of culture as “pure,” unadulterated, and unaffected by other circumstances and contexts, they view learning as a process that takes place within ongoing activity.⁶ Gutierrez and Rogoff thus distinguish between *understanding cultural practices* and *locating cultural characteristics* because the latter can be problematic.⁷ Using the previous example, we would be in error to view Latino culture as *always* interdependent, regardless of the situation. Culture is too complex and too varied for us to conclude that all those who share a particular background behave in the same way or believe the same things.

■ Hybridity: Another Way of Understanding Culture

One problem with a static view of culture is that it fails to recognize that our society is more heterogeneous than ever. As you can see in the case studies of young people in this chapter, many of them have multiple identities: Rebecca is not only a lesbian but *also* Italian American; Yahaira is Dominican *and* Puerto Rican; James is Lebanese and a bike rider. In the case of these young people, *all* of their identities are significant to them. With multiple identities of this kind becoming more and more common, it is impossible to speak about culture as it is lived today, in this context, as if it were unitary. A major premise of this book is that a static view of culture contradicts the very notion of multicultural education as presented here.

This brings us to a discussion of *hybridity*, that is, the fusion of various cultures to form new, distinct, and ever-changing identities. Growing up amidst a range of cultural influences that substantively shape one’s development and worldview contributes to cultural hybridity, which is a reality in our own country as well as internationally. It refers not simply to mixed-race and ethnic identity because the conceptual understandings of hybridity have grown with the awareness of the limitations of racial categories. This is evident at the institutional level of the U.S. Census Bureau, which provides the following statement on its website and census forms:

The racial categories included in the census questionnaire generally reflect a social definition of race recognized in this country, and not an attempt to define race biologically, anthropologically or genetically. People may choose to report more than one race to indicate their racial mixture, such as “American Indian and White.” People who identify their origin as Hispanic, Latino, or Spanish may be of any race. In addition, it is recognized that the categories of the race item include both racial and national origin or socio-cultural groups. You may choose more than one race category.⁸

Of the 2010 U.S. population of 308,745,538 (estimated), approximately 1.7 percent reported two or more races in their responses to the U.S. Census. Clearly, what has been called mixed-race, multiracial, biracial, and multi-ethnic identity is certainly a growing reality. About 4 percent of youth under age 18 in the United States are of mixed heritage, and the number is growing rapidly. Alejandra Lopez-Torkos argues that we need to learn to talk about identity in different ways, “allowing for fluidity and multiplicity in racial-ethnic identification.”⁹ But understandings

of hybridity go far beyond listing more than one racial category. This need for fluidity is also closely tied to conceptions of multilingualism in schools. María E. Torres-Guzman and Ester J. de Jong point out that multilingualism needs to be broadly defined, and that views of multilingualism have evolved over time.¹⁰ Their research traces the historical developments of multilingualism to focus on the relationship between language, culture, race and poverty, and how multilingualism is a negotiated, lived experience for students, especially in urban areas and in what Juan Guerra has called transcultural repositioning.¹¹

Some examples can help explain this kind of fluidity and repositioning. In an ethnographic study of a large, urban, and culturally diverse high school, Laurie Olsen described how immigrant students felt “caught in the middle,” not really fitting into any category. She found that the “sides” were constantly shifting: While identity was sometimes defined in terms of nationality, at other times it was defined in terms of culture, religion, race, or language and sometimes as a combination of these.¹² In another example, Pedro Noguera’s research with Mexican American students in East Oakland illustrates how context influences identity. When they were in elementary school, the Mexican American children were described by African American classmates—and frequently referred to themselves—as “White.” However, in the new social contexts of adolescence and middle school, they began to view themselves as Mexican Americans, among other identities.¹³ Daniel Yon’s research in a Toronto high school illustrates similar complexities: He found, for example, that a Serbian identified as “Spanish,” while a White male identified strongly with Guyanese. Yon refers to the shifting notions of identity as “elusive culture,” that is, a view of culture as an ongoing process that includes not only race and ethnicity but also popular culture.¹⁴

Beyond Race and Ethnicity

Hybridity, then, also refers to *how* people identify, regardless of which ethnic, cultural, or racial group they may belong to. It recognizes that there are many other identities besides race and ethnicity; these may include gender, sexual orientation, geographic location, and professional affiliation, among many others. That is, hybridity substantiates Nadine Dolby’s point that identity is not “an absolute state of being,” but rather a variable that is constantly shifting and changing.¹⁵ For example, urban youth often identify with a culture that is an amalgam of various ethnic, racial, and other identifications. Researchers Nikola Hobbel and Thandeka K. Chapman argue for conceptualizing identity as *process* and as *category*, calling attention to the signs of alliance across unlikely borders. They emphasize, “No single aspect of the expression of identity can fully account for cultural and historical context, even given the fact that race has consistently assumed a central role in America’s history and imagination.”¹⁶ Hip-hop culture is a good example of this: Incorporating music, dance, visual culture, as well as working-class and often marginalized urban perspectives, hip-hop represents a unique culture that is not tied to any one ethnic or racial group although it began in urban communities of color. In fact, it is not unusual in many suburban, primarily White middle schools and high schools to see young people identifying principally with urban hip-hop culture, even though many of these young people have never lived in cities or known people of color. Recognizing the complexity in culture allows us to understand the many and varied identities taken on by young people.

Influence of Culture on Learning

Learning is at the core of our discussion of culture. That is, we are not interested in exploring culture simply for the sake of developing awareness of cultural differences or developing sensitivity to students of diverse backgrounds. These are also important goals, but considering the troubling history of underachievement and

marginalization of students of particular backgrounds in our schools—especially students of color and poor students of all backgrounds—the first priority must be understanding how educators and schools view students' cultures and how their perceptions may, as a result, influence students' learning and achievement.

While culture is integral to the learning process, it may affect individuals differently. In other words, *culture is not destiny*. Given differences in social class and family structure, individual psychological and emotional differences and experiences, birth order, residence, and a host of other individual and social distinctions, it is folly to think that culture alone accounts for all human differences. Anyone who has children can confirm this truth: Two offspring from the same parents, with the same culture and social class, and raised in substantially the same way, can turn out to be as different as night and day. Hence, culture is neither static nor deterministic; it gives us just one way in which to understand differences among students. The assumption that culture is the primary determinant of academic achievement can be oversimplistic, dangerous, and counterproductive because, although culture may *influence*, it does not *determine* who we are.

Everyone participates in culture, but many times, members of the culturally dominant group of a society do not even think of themselves as cultural beings. For them, culture is something that other people have, especially people who differ from the mainstream in race or ethnicity. The problem with conceptualizing culture in this way is that it tends to "exoticize" those people who are not in the cultural mainstream (and who also, not incidentally, tend to be the most powerless in society). A more complicated view of culture is needed, especially among teachers whose classrooms are becoming more diverse every day. There are vast differences among learners within ethnic groups, and these differences may be due not just to culture but also to social class, language spoken at home, number of years or generations in the United States, and simple individual differences.

Let us take the example of social class, an aspect of identity that may be as important as ethnicity in influencing learning. Because membership within a particular social group is based on economic factors as well as cultural values, the working class may differ from the middle class not only in particular values and practices, but also in the amount and kinds of economic resources they have at their disposal. Because of these differences, gross generalizations may be made, thus perpetuating what has been called "the culture of poverty," that is, a view of poverty that sees the poor as having no culture or having a culture that is without any merit whatsoever. Thus, the "culture of poverty" pathologizes the values and actions of working-class and poor people.

Educators need to become acquainted with far better analyses of poverty, which, are grounded in an understanding of the larger structural issues that create and sustain poverty. Paul Gorski's research rejects deficit perspectives and provides strategies to create what he calls a *pedagogy of engagement* for students in poverty, classroom practices that are both *instructional* and *relational*. At the same time, he insists that there is no package of strategies that work for all low-income children; rather, it is always necessary to partner with people in the community to learn more specifics about learners' needs.¹⁷ Also, he cautions that the dispositions we bring to our relations with low-income families will greatly influence our effectiveness. With that in mind, and within a sociopolitical analysis of the influences of socioeconomic class on students' learning, Gorski suggests the following strategies for classrooms and schools:

- Express high expectations through higher-order, engaging pedagogies.
- Enhance family involvement.
- Incorporate arts into instruction.
- Incorporate movement into instruction.

- Focus intently on student and family strengths.
- Analyze materials for class bias.
- Promote literacy enjoyment.
- Reach out to families early and often.¹⁸

He also urges educators to expand our spheres of influence by taking on some larger social issues of equity that would be particularly beneficial to expanding educational opportunities for children living in poverty, such as:

- Advocate for universal preschool.
- Nurture relationships with community agencies, including health clinics and farms (to promote the production and consumption of fresh food).
- Reduce class sizes.
- Increase health services in schools.¹⁹

Gorski's scholarship supports the tenets of this book. His research points to practices rooted in an ideology of equity, and he underscores the ways in which educational policy influences practice. In the case of students in poverty, the inequalities in the educational and social environments must be addressed.²⁰ This work is a direct counterpoint to some popular books and professional development programs such as Ruby Payne's *A Framework for Understanding Poverty* and Eric Jensen's *Teaching with Poverty in Mind*, which perpetuate the ideology of deficiencies and the myth of the "culture of poverty."²¹

Notwithstanding these caveats about overdetermining its significance, we want to emphasize that culture *is* important. One reason for insisting on the significance of culture is that some people, primarily those from dominated and disenfranchised groups within society, have been taught that they have no culture. This has resulted in, among other things, what Felix Boateng has called *deculturalization*, that is, a process by which people are first deprived of their own culture, and then conditioned into embracing other cultural values.²² This is how the patronizing term *cultural deprivation* has come to imply that a group is without culture altogether, although in reality what it means is that some people do not share in the culture of the dominant group. The research cited in this chapter underscores one of the central tenets of multicultural education: *Everybody participates in culture*—that is, everybody has the ability to create and re-create ideas and material goods and to affect their world in a variety of ways.

Multicultural education is one way of counteracting the notion that culture is reserved for the privileged. For example, Hoang Vinh, although only 18 years old when he was interviewed for our case study, had a more sophisticated understanding of culture than do many adults. As you will see, Vinh described Vietnamese cultural values, behaviors, and expectations without falling into simplistic explanations for complex phenomena. He was also very accurate in pointing out cultural differences between his teachers in Vietnam and the United States: He said that one of his teachers, Ms. Mitchell, expected all students to do things in the same way but that people from other countries "have different ideas, so they might think about school in different ways. . . . So she has to learn about that culture." As one example, he described how his English teachers praised him for his fluency in English, although he felt that instead they should have been telling him to study more. He concluded, "But that's the way the American culture is. But my culture is not like that."

Cultural differences in learning may be especially apparent in three areas: *learning styles or preferences*, *interactional or communication styles*, and *language differences*. Examples of the first two areas are explored next in this chapter. Language and language issues are considered more fully in Chapter 6, although it should be understood that language is a major component of culture and is also part of the discussion here.

■ Learning Styles, Preferences, Intelligences, and Power

Learning style is usually defined as the way in which individuals receive and process information with the understanding that individuals think and learn best in different ways.²³ Exactly how culture influences learning and learning style is unclear. For example, an extensive review of scholarship on models of learning styles found the field to be wide-ranging and conceptually confusing. There are many and diverse approaches to defining, measuring, and describing learning styles. Many scholars assert that a reliable measure or categorization of learning styles has not yet been found. These reports cautioned that considering learning styles as a fixed trait could lead educators to labeling students and mislead them to believe that such traits cannot be altered. It can also promote a misguided prescribed view of “matching” teaching and learning styles that could be limiting to students. These reports suggest that educators’ time and energy are better spent on investigating theories and practices that more authentically aid instruction.²⁴

In spite of the advances made in understanding how culture might influence learning, the linear process implied by learning style theory is not convincing. In fact, some of the early research in this field concentrated on ethnic and racial differences in learning, a perspective that can skirt dangerously close to racist perceptions of differences in IQ. It also flies in the face of cultural hybridity and negates the vast pool of learners who adapt to multiple learning situations and to a range of cultural experiences.

A focus on rigid learning styles is problematic because of its tendency to dichotomize learning; it is doubtful that a process as complex as learning can be characterized as having only two poles, four quadrants, or five characteristics, whatever the theory may assert. Hence, we use the term *learning preferences* because it is a more flexible way of approaching differences in learning. A good example is the case of Hoang Vinh, who loved working in cooperative groups, a learning preference that is not usually associated with Vietnamese students. Thus, although learning-style research can be helpful in identifying learning differences related to ethnicity and culture, its misapplication also runs the risk of oversimplification and stereotyping and can be used as a rationale for poor or inequitable teaching.

How learning-style theory can be misapplied is evident in reviews of research on American Indian and Alaska Native education. For example, Donna Deyhle and Karen Swisher concluded that while learning-style research can point to meaningful adaptations that may improve the educational outcomes of these students, they also warned of the detrimental consequences of viewing learning-style research uncritically. Specifically, they pointed out that the depiction of the “nonverbal” Indian child is reinforced when teachers read that American Indian students prefer observation to performance. They emphasize that it is crucial for teachers to understand power relations in the classroom, and how these may be even more significant than supposed learning styles.²⁵ Deyhle builds on that research in the lessons she learned from the young Navajo men and women with whom she worked in a more recent study, which echo the themes of this book. While reflecting on diverse learning needs, she emphasizes, “Clearly, cultures don’t represent a seamless whole. And identities are situational, contradictory, and divergently shaped by social, political, and economic forces.”²⁶ She noted that these students address the inequalities of colonization and their schooling as they assert their Indigenous knowledge while stating these six learning needs:

Lesson 1: “Know who I am!”

Lesson 2: “I am not the same as my grandparents, and don’t use this against me.”

Lesson 3: “Believe in me and appreciate me.”

Lesson 4: “We want a rich and exciting schooling experience.”

Lesson 5: “I want to learn my language and culture.”

Lesson 6: “I’ll never give up who I am.”²⁷

Navajo researcher Kathryn Manuelito has also underscored the importance of incorporating Native American epistemologies in schooling for Indigenous students while indicting the power relations that can impede Native students' educational achievement.²⁸

Power Differences

An example of debilitating power relations can be seen in the case study of James Karam that follows later in this chapter. Although the Arabic language and Lebanese culture were very important to James, they were essentially invisible in his school. As a result, he learned to deemphasize them in the school setting. This kind of "invisibility" of Arab Americans and their culture was reversed after the events of 9/11. A new type of harmful visibility experienced by many Arab Americans in school involves "racial profiling" by peers, whereby some students—and even some adults—may disparage their culture, language, appearance, and religion and make unfounded, prejudicial accusations. In such a climate, the learning of all students is negatively affected.

Thus, the sociopolitical context, as well as a constellation of factors such as child-rearing practices and cultural experiences, wield substantial influence on students' learning preferences. Circumstances such as power relationships and status differentials are also at work, and these may be even more substantial than child-rearing practices. These power differentials are evident in Rebecca Florentina's comments, summarized in her case study at the end of this chapter. Quite astute in understanding how curriculum and pedagogy can malign students' identities, Rebecca suggested that the major problem in health class was the curriculum and that one way to address this problem was to "get the health teachers to put better curriculum for teaching about same sex, transgender, anything, you know?"

Multiple Intelligences and Multicultural Education

Although not specifically related to cultural differences or even related to multicultural education, Howard Gardner's theory of multiple intelligences (MI) from the field of cognitive science and education has implications for culturally compatible education.²⁹ According to Gardner's theory, each human being possesses eight or nine relatively independent forms of information processing, and each is a specific "intelligence." These intelligences include logical-mathematical, linguistic (these first two are the most emphasized in school success), musical, spatial, bodily kinesthetic, interpersonal, naturalistic, intrapersonal, and the ninth—about which Gardner continues to speculate—existential. Accordingly, Gardner defines *intelligence* as the ability to solve problems or develop products that are valued in a particular cultural setting. The salience of cultural differences in descriptions of intelligence is evident. Gardner's research has demonstrated that individuals differ in the specific profile of intelligences that they exhibit, and these differences may be influenced by what is valued in their culture. Because a broader range of abilities is acknowledged in this conception of intelligence, previously discounted talents of individuals can be considered in a new light.

However, MI theory can also be misapplied. Gardner reports that he "objected strenuously" to a statewide educational intervention "that described major racial and ethnic groups in Australia in terms of the intelligences that they purportedly had and the ones that they purportedly lacked."³⁰ He recently launched a website called Multiple Intelligences Oasis as the repository of authoritative, reliable research in a sea of claims about MI theory. The website is replete with research and resources designed specifically to support continued inquiry about MI theory, while countering some of the misinformation that is sometimes practiced in its name.³¹ The website builds on a paper he released on the 25th anniversary of the publication of his groundbreaking book *Frames of Mind: The Theory of Multiple*

Intelligences; the paper addressed some of the myths and misunderstanding of MI theory—for example, confusing an intelligence with a learning style, or claiming that all children are strong in at least one intelligence. He asserts that any serious application of MI ideas should entail at least two components: (1) an attempt to individuate education as much as possible and (2) a commitment to convey important ideas and concepts in a number of different formats.³² Gardner has branched into the policy arena to focus not only on how human beings should be *understood* by scientific study, but also on how they should be *nurtured* by educational institutions. His more recent theory, articulated in his book *Five Minds for the Future*, describes these five minds as (1) the disciplined mind, (2) the synthesizing mind, (3) the creative mind, (4) the respectful mind, and (5) the ethical mind.³³

The theories of multiple intelligences and of five minds may have significant implications for multicultural education because these theories go beyond the limited definition of intelligence valued in most schools. Since Gardner's theories break out of the rigid definition of intelligence narrowly defined as book knowledge or doing well on standardized tests, they may be particularly helpful in challenging current assessment practices that focus almost exclusively on logical-mathematical and linguistic intelligence. Understanding multiple intelligences may provide guidance in helping educators reconsider the role that schools play in cultivating participation in a democratic society. The danger, as always, lies in extrapolating from individual cases to an entire group. Although it may be true, for example, that a certain culture—because of its social, geographic, or political circumstances—is more highly developed in one kind of intelligence than other cultures, educators should not conclude that all the group's members will manifest this intelligence equally. They should also not assume that individuals from this culture are *primarily* or *only* intelligent in one way and therefore unable to develop intelligence in other areas.

■ Communication and Pedagogy

Cultural influences can also be evident in interactional or communication styles, that is, the ways individuals interact with one another and the messages they send, intentionally or not, in their communications. According to Geneva Gay, communication is much more than the content and structuring of written and spoken language. She states,

Sociocultural context and nuances, discourse logic and dynamics, delivery styles, social functions, role expectations, norms of interaction, and nonverbal gestures are as important (if not more so) than vocabulary, grammar, lexicon, pronunciation, and other linguistic structural dimensions of communication.³⁴

If teachers and schools are unaware of these differences and the impact they can have on learning, the result may be cultural conflict that leads to school failure. School failure, in this case, can be understood as the product of miscommunication between teachers and students and a rational adaptation by students who are devalued by schools. Following this line of thought, unless changes are made in learning environments, school failure may be inevitable.

Roland Tharp in his now historical review of culturally compatible education concluded that when schools become more attuned to children's cultures, academic achievement improves.³⁵ Tharp suggested at least four cultural variables related to communication that may be at odds with the expectations and structures of schools: *social organization*, *sociolinguistics*, *cognition*, and *motivation*.

Tharp followed up this research with Stephanie Stoll Dalton in collaboration with the Center for Research on Education, Diversity and Excellence (CREDE) and realized the limitations of classrooms strictly organized according to culturally compatible education. For example, what happens when you have classroom

What You Can Do

Teach Through the Transformational Inquiry Method

The way in which teachers approach topics of human difference and student identity can make or break the classroom experience. Moreover, as we point out in this section of the book, cultivating teacher awareness of the multiplicity and intersectionality of student identity is essential to a positive learning experience. Teachers Martha Caldwell and Oman Frame offer a classroom practice they call “The Transformational Inquiry Method” in their book *Let’s Get Real*.^{*} This book provides helpful frameworks for facilitating dynamic classroom dialogue that provide a solid classroom foundation

for inquiry into identity, replete with sample lessons and handouts for lessons on inquiry into race, social class, gender, and more. This resource is not cookbook-style or a script; rather, it provides guidance for you to cultivate the transformation inquiry method in your classroom, with attention to the expanding and flexible cultural identities that your students bring to your classroom.

^{*}Caldwell, M., & Frame, O. (2017). *Let’s get real: Exploring race, class, and gender identities in the classroom*. New York: Routledge.

demographics that include students representing a range of diverse groups, such as Navajo, African American, Cambodian, Irish American, and Greek? The exponential growth of classrooms that hold a range of multilingual, multi-ethnic, multiracial, and multicultural learners in the ensuing 30 years since Tharp’s initial research led Tharp and Dalton to offer “five standards for effective pedagogy” that can guide teachers in meaningful practice for students of all cultural backgrounds.³⁶ Dalton expanded on these in her book *Five Standards for Effective Teaching*, in which she provides classroom practices that demonstrate the following: (1) teachers and students producing together, (2) developing language and literacy across the curriculum, (3) connecting school to students’ lives, (4) teaching complex thinking, and (5) teaching through instructional conversation. In summary, these five standards guide what they call a “pedagogy system” that includes both collaborative group and individual work; activities linking curriculum to the strengths, needs, and interests of local communities; and the rich dialogic language environments of multiple, simultaneous classroom activity settings.³⁷

How relationships between students and teachers can be either improved or damaged by their interactions is another pertinent area of research on culturally responsive classrooms. As an example, students and teachers from the same background are often on the same wavelength simply because they have an insider’s understanding of cultural meanings and therefore do not have to figure out the verbal and nonverbal messages they are sending. In the two decades since Michele Foster examined how a shared cultural background or shared norms about how language is used in African American communities can benefit classroom interactions, a great deal has been written about African American Vernacular English (AAVE).³⁸ The research about classroom practices is mixed. Rebecca Wheeler’s scholarship on fostering teachers’ habits of mind about AAVE found obstacles to bringing these linguistic insights into teacher education classrooms and PK–12 classrooms. The obstacles include teachers’ dominant language ideology and prior lack of training in the structure of English. Her research suggests strategies for guiding teachers in ways of thinking about grammar, AAVE, and Standard American English (SAE).³⁹ Wheeler also points out that theories and practices about AAVE have not taken root in schools, despite the scholarship of linguistic scholars and critical language theorists.⁴⁰

More examples of communication style are needed for teachers to learn about successful classroom strategies, such as research on urban youth culture by Ernest Morrell and Jeff Duncan-Andrade who used their students’ involvement with hip-hop culture to successfully engage them in literacy learning.⁴¹ In Christopher

Emdin's book *For White Folks Who Teach in the Hood . . . and the Rest of Y'all Too*, he presents the practice of "reality pedagogy" as "an approach to teaching and learning that has the primary goal of meeting each student on his or her own cultural and emotional turf."⁴² Part of reality pedagogy includes privileging the dialectal practices of urban students, which he refers to as *neo-indigenous language* to help students understand code switching. This acknowledges that there are different contexts or worlds in which students use language, and each world has its own language code. Emdin gives the example of displaying a classroom chart that compares vocabulary across three codes: traditional English; language of science; and slang, or neo-indigenous language. He shows the term "emit" as science language, side by side with "shine" as traditional English, and "bling" as slang.⁴³ Emdin's research argues for teaching youth to code switch through classroom exercises that welcome their local colloquialisms, while teaching them the distinctive contexts in which various speech practices are used. They gain understandings of "socially constructed codes and rules while maintaining their own cultural identities."⁴⁴

Carol Lee's research on the literacy practices of African American high school students also showed that cultural resources support learning. In analyzing students' everyday practices, Lee found that African American students who speak Ebonics, or African American Vernacular English (AAVE), consistently use irony, satire, and symbolism in their everyday talk, especially in the speech genre *signifying*, that is, ritualistic insults and other word games. Because of their creative use of language, Lee reasoned that building on this kind of knowledge and skills would be an effective basis for a literature curriculum because, in Lee's words, "[u]se of rhythm, alliteration, metaphor, irony, and satire are routine in the language practices of this speech community."⁴⁵ As a result of this understanding, Lee developed the Cultural Modeling Project, a four-year literature curriculum that has been implemented in a large midwestern city. The result: Students at all grade levels have achieved beyond what their standardized reading scores predicted.⁴⁶

Cultural differences likely influence students in more ways than we can imagine. For example, take the case of Susan, a new teacher who was attending a workshop being given by me (Sonia) many years ago. Susan was a young teacher of English as a Second Language to Puerto Rican students. Although she was sincerely committed to her students' achievement, she was unaware of many aspects of their culture. The Puerto Rican children, most of whom had recently arrived in the United States, used the communication style typical of their culture. For example, many Puerto Ricans wrinkle their noses to signify "What?" When Susan would ask the children if they understood the lesson, some would invariably wrinkle their noses. Not understanding this gesture, Susan simply went on with the lesson, assuming that their nose wrinkling had no meaning.

Two years after first being exposed to this behavior, Susan attended a workshop in which we discussed Puerto Rican gestures and the work of Carmen Judith Nine-Curt in the area of nonverbal communication. She learned that nose wrinkling among Puerto Ricans was a way of asking "What?" or "What do you mean?" or of saying, "I don't understand."⁴⁷ From then on, Susan understood that, when her students exhibited this form of nonverbal communication, they were asking for help or for further clarification. We all laughed about it that day in the workshop, but this humorous anecdote is not without its serious consequences. Students whose culture, verbal or nonverbal, is unacknowledged or misunderstood in their classrooms are likely to feel alienated, unwelcome, and out of place.

Promoting teachers' familiarity with communication differences would go a long way in helping them transform their curriculum to address their students' backgrounds more adequately. The communication styles explored here are only the tip of the iceberg, but they help to point out the sometimes subtle ways that culture, if it is not understood, can interfere with learning.

What You Can Do

Research Families' Funds of Knowledge

Explore who your students are, what makes them “tick,” and the values and life skills of their families. Doing so will help you understand the strengths that families have, rather than focusing on assumed weaknesses or deficits.

If you are an elementary-level teacher, make it a point to visit your students' families at least once a year. Focus on learning about what Norma Gonzalez, Luis Moll, and Cathy Amanti have called “families' funds of knowledge”—that is, their skills and competencies—and think about how you can use these in your curriculum. To learn more about doing such research, see their book.*

Considering the large number of students they teach, it is unrealistic to expect secondary school teachers to engage in such research. However, there are other projects that can help you, as a secondary school teacher, become familiar with your students' cultures and identities. Oral histories are an excellent

way to learn about your students' family histories, challenges, and triumphs. Oral histories do not need to be confined to the English or social studies class. Math, health, science, art, and other subject matters are fertile ground for case studies. You'll be surprised at how much you can learn—and use in your curriculum—from conducting this kind of project.

Another helpful approach is called *Biography-Driven Culturally Responsive Teaching* and is explained in a book of the same title by Socorro Herrera.† This practical, hands-on, how-to resource guides teachers in classroom practices that are rooted in well-researched theory.

*Gonzalez, N. E., Moll, L., & Amanti, C. (Eds.) (2005). *Funds of knowledge: Theorizing practices in households and classrooms*. Mahwah, NJ: Lawrence Erlbaum.

†Herrera, Socorro. (2016). *Biography-Driven Culturally Responsive Teaching* (2nd ed.). New York: Teachers College Press.

Cultural Discontinuities and School Achievement

Cultural discontinuities, that is, the lack of congruence between home and school cultures, may cause numerous problems for students from culturally marginalized groups. A review of some of the literature on culture-specific educational accommodations can pinpoint how cultural differences between schools and students' home lives may lead to negative academic outcomes.

Discontinuities in Language

A classic research study that paved the way for numerous other studies by anthropologists, sociolinguists, and educators was done by Shirley Brice Heath in the Piedmont Carolinas during the 1970s.⁴⁸ In exploring the language of Black children at home and at school, she found that different ways of using language resulted in tensions between the children and their mostly White teachers in the classroom. For example, the children were not accustomed to answering questions concerning the attributes of objects (color, size, shape, etc.), the kinds of questions that typically occur in classroom discourse as well as in middle-class homes (i.e., “What color is the car?” “How many dolls are there?”). Instead, the children generally used descriptive language at home for storytelling and other purposes. The result was a communication breakdown, with teachers believing that many of the students were “slow” and students perceiving a lack of support from teachers. Through research coordinated by Heath, the teachers began to experiment with different ways of asking questions. The result was that teachers helped children bridge the gap between their home and school experiences and thus the children's language use in the classroom was enhanced. Heath continues to bring critical reflections of these findings in her current research, in which she considers the implications of contemporary social conditions that are creating changes in family interaction and discourse. She suggest, for example, that emerging technologies and lifestyle shifts create changes in language use, which influence what we refer to as family literacy. As a result, she makes the case for placing value on

community literacies in texts of all forms: oral and written, visual and verbal, that comprise projects of joint work and play.⁴⁹

Discontinuities in Perspectives on School Achievement

Cultural discontinuities do not develop, however, simply because of differing cultural values among groups. There is often a direct connection between culture and the sociopolitical context of schooling. One example of the link between sociopolitical context and culture is the academic success of many Asian students in U.S. schools. The National Center for Education Statistics reported that in the 2013–14 school year, the graduation rate for public high schools was 82 percent—an all-time high. Asian/Pacific Islander students had the highest graduation rate (89 percent), followed by White (87 percent), Hispanic (76 percent), Black (73 percent), and American Indian/Alaska Native (70 percent) students.⁵⁰ The prevailing explanation for their success is that the cultural values of some Asian students are congruent with the academic culture of schools. Although this may be true, it alone is not sufficient to explain their success; it is also problematic because it paints the entire Asian American population with one wide brush. Some sociopolitical factors are at play in these statistics. The fact that the parents of South Asian students are the most highly educated among all immigrants is also a factor. For instance, on average, Asian Americans have a higher level of education than any other ethnic group in the nation. In 2015, 54 percent of Asians in the U.S. held a bachelor's degree or higher, up from 38 percent in 1995, according to the U.S. Census Bureau. This is also greater than the overall rate of 33 percent for the total population of people holding bachelor's degree or higher. In addition, Asians and non-Hispanic whites were more likely to hold a bachelor's degree or higher when compared with blacks and Hispanics.⁵¹

However, the level of education depends to a great extent on categories of Asian ethnicity. In California, a report found that 20 percent of Pacific Islanders in the state eventually drop out of high school. Hmong have a 45 percent rate of not attaining a high school diploma, with Cambodia and Laotians at a 40 percent drop-out rate in California.⁵² As we can see, national identity and cultural groups are multifaceted categories, and the sociopolitical context of educational achievement cannot easily be separated from other issues, such as social class, parents' level of education, and students' access to higher education.

Confronting Myths to Address Discontinuities

Stacey Lee's research points to the limits of the cultural explanation of academic success among Asian American students. First, it does not account for within-group differences in achievement. She points out that the cultural theory seems plausible for high achievement, but it does not explain low achievement, neglecting the question of why some Asian American students do poorly in school. Other problems with the cultural explanation include considerations of why some Asians struggle with academic achievement in their own country where they are engulfed in their home culture, and why studies of specific Asian ethnic groups show low achievement in some countries but not in others. Lee's work also sends a strong caution against the "model-minority stereotype" that falsely perpetuates the assumptions that all Asian and Asian American students do well in school. She points out that the stereotype is used to silence claims of racial inequality, and it hides the problems faced by some Asian American students. It also influences the way many Asian students view themselves and their achievements.⁵³

Nicholas Daniel Hartlep's research also refutes the model minority stereotype: He asserts that the stereotype often goes unrecognized because it is hidden behind ideologies of meritocracy, ahistoricism, and racial color-blindness. These perspectives perpetuate the cultural discontinuities for students from a wide range of Asian and Asian American experiences by diminishing the unique histories

and contemporary situations of each specific community, and certainly of each individual student and family. As the recent data underscore, the South Asian American community has experienced U.S. schools differently from the Cambodian American community. Having said that, each family and student bring their own complexities to bear on the outcomes of their schooling as well. Moreover, the persistence of institutionalized racism can prevent schools from addressing each student's learning needs and identities. The academic achievement of students who are recent immigrants, as well as those whose families have lived in the United States for multiple generations, is contorted by what Hartlep calls the modern societal impact of the model minority stereotype.⁵⁴

Historical Causes of Discontinuities

The deep-seeded myths and stereotypes that cause cultural discontinuities in education highlight the sociopolitical context embedded in the history of U.S. schooling. One tragic example is illustrated by the practice, in the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, of sending American Indian students to distant boarding schools. Attending such schools meant that students were physically separated from their parents and consequently from their cultural connections. The very purpose of these boarding schools was to eradicate students' Native language and culture in an attempt to "Americanize" them.⁵⁵ The dropout rate among these students was extraordinarily high because of the school-related social and emotional problems they experienced both during and after being sent to boarding schools. Although the dropout rate of American Indians remains catastrophically high in some areas, as documented by the Civil Rights Project, it has been reduced dramatically in cases where secondary education has been returned to local communities.⁵⁶

Becoming aware of the sociopolitical context of education is important for other reasons, too. For instance, in their research on American Indians, Deyhle and her colleagues have expressed the concern that educators sometimes use the cultural discontinuity theory to argue only for a culturally compatible curriculum to solve the dropout problem.⁵⁷ In so doing, educators may neglect to confront other more pressing problems in American Indian and Alaskan Native schools, such as the lack of equitable financing and appropriate resources.

The same concerns apply to students from other non mainstream backgrounds, as pointed out by Tyrone Howard's book in which he illustrates case studies of three schools in which educators were instrumental in increasing the understanding of race and culture. The result has been that the academic achievement of young people of color has increased in impressive ways as teachers have made more rigorous demands of the students.⁵⁸ Another example of the enduring messages and complexity of school culture can be found in the case of LGBTQ students who may not do well in school. The problem is likely not lack of intelligence or a cultural mismatch with the school, but rather the rejection they experience in school as a result of the school's unwelcoming climate. Changing the curriculum would probably help, but in some cases, LGBTQ students may decide that dropping out of school is the only recourse they have. In his book *Safe is Not Enough: Better Schools for LGBTQ Students*, Michael Sadowski addresses these multifaceted aspects of classroom and school reform that are required to transform the school climate for LGBTQ students so they may thrive.⁵⁹ Rebecca Florentina, in the case study that concludes this chapter, mentions a number of friends who would have benefited from Sadowski's research.

These examples demonstrate that cultural incompatibilities are varied and complex. Research concerning them is vital if we are to grasp how children from different cultural backgrounds respond to teachers' behaviors, and what teachers can do to change how they teach. However, no single solution will bridge the gap between the school and the home cultures of all students.

■ Culturally Relevant, Responsive, and Sustaining Education

Various approaches and programs have been designed to provide for the particular educational needs of students from specific cultural groups, and some of these programs have proved to be extremely successful. A number of examples of modifications to make instruction more culturally appropriate reveal the reasoning behind the approach known variously as *culturally compatible*, *culturally congruent*, *culturally appropriate*, *culturally responsive*, or *culturally relevant instruction*.⁶⁰

Research that provides examples of the pedagogy of teachers with students of diverse backgrounds provides convincing illustrations of how teachers use cultural knowledge and experiences to overcome some of the debilitating and negative messages of schools and society. It also documents how the most effective teachers challenge students rather than let them “slide.” Jacqueline Jordan Irvine and James Fraser describe culturally responsive teachers of African American students as “warm demanders,” that is, teachers who are affectionate and loving while they are tough and rigorous in their expectations.⁶¹ Gloria Ladson-Billings’s research of effective teachers of African American students also documents how successful teachers use students’ culture as a bridge to the dominant culture. The pedagogy of the effective teachers she describes is empowering because, rather than simply teach students blind acceptance of the inherent values of the dominant culture, these teachers encourage students to think critically and work actively for social justice.⁶²

Culturally Sustaining Pedagogy

Throughout the past 30 years, the terminology and approaches for cultural responsiveness have been embraced by many, and have advanced the efforts of critically minded multicultural educators. Building on those decades of research and practice, researcher, Django Paris argues for the necessity to change stance, terminology, and practice by offering the term *culturally sustaining pedagogy* as an alternative that, he suggests, expresses some of the best historical research and contemporary practice in multicultural education. He explains:

Culturally sustaining pedagogy seeks to perpetuate and foster—to sustain—linguistic, literate, and cultural pluralism as part of the democratic project of schooling. In the face of current policies and practices that have the explicit goal of creating a monocultural and monolingual society, research and practice need equally explicit resistances that embrace cultural pluralism and cultural equality.⁶³

Paris expounded on this stance with H. Samy Alim to argue for teaching that keeps pace with the changing lives and practices of youth of color, while remaining attentive to the constantly evolving global world. Their research continues to ask questions about the purpose of schooling in a pluralistic society by focusing on the evolving nature of youth identity and cultural practices, with a commitment to embracing youth culture’s potential to confront and interrogate imbalance of power.⁶⁴ Notably, Gloria Ladson-Billings, who first asserted the terminology “Culturally Relevant Pedagogy” (CRP) in 1995, has welcomed the advancement of culturally sustaining pedagogy as a means to expand her original goals of CRP with fluid understandings of culture, while deliberately engaging questions of equity and justice.⁶⁵

These practices are highlighted by H. Richard Milner’s edited text that demonstrates the critical importance of teachers understanding the context of their students’ lives and the implications of their own identities and their students’ identities when building productive relationships for learning. The authors in this collection emphasize the good news that teachers of all backgrounds can learn to be culturally responsive.⁶⁶ In addition to considering the competencies of teachers

who are successful with African American students, these studies document additional effective practices, including teachers' use of interactive rather than didactic methods, and the high standards they set for students.

An illustration in which teachers are effective with students of color, despite the fact that the cultural identities of teachers and students were not always the same, is found in research by Jason G. Irizarry. Drawing on a larger ethnographic study in the Northeast, he highlighted Mr. Talbert (a pseudonym), an African American teacher who used a variety of practices, including community connections (sharing personal stories, living in the same community, and knowing what went on in the neighborhood), language (i.e., supporting various uses of written and spoken language of students, including Ebonics, or Black English), and music (particularly rap), to relate to his students, while he also demanded high-quality work from them.⁶⁷

Irizarry's more recent research illustrates the tenets of culturally sustaining pedagogy as described in his book *The Latinization of U.S. Schools: Successful Teaching and Learning in Shifting Cultural Contexts*. Each chapter is co-authored with Latino high school students with whom he facilitated a Youth Participatory Action Research (YPAR) project. With a focus on affirming students' identities and cultural practices, while harnessing their attention, in rigorous research that addressed their educational needs and their community's resources, Irizarry provides a picture of engaging youth in resistance to systemic oppressions while becoming agents of change.

These dramatic examples focus on one cultural group in a school, but changes in instruction and curriculum that reflect the multicultural character of most schools are also possible. For example, most schools favor a highly competitive and individualistic instructional mode in which only some of the students may be successful. By combining this style with a more cooperative mode, the learning and cultural styles of all children can be respected and valued. The lesson is that, although all schools cannot become fully *culturally compatible* because of the range of diversity in the student body, they can become *multiculturally sensitive*, *culturally sustaining*, and *critically conscious* of their learners' needs.

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A Critical Appraisal of Culture-Specific Accommodations

Culturally sustaining pedagogies should not be confused with culture-specific accommodations. Many schools are multicultural, with students from diverse ethnic, social class, and linguistic backgrounds. There are few schools with totally homogeneous populations. Even within a so-called homogeneous group, cultural experiences, expressions, and identities will certainly be embodied in a variety of ways. For these reasons, and in spite of their usefulness, culture-specific accommodations are limited by several factors. First, the diversity of the student population in most schools mitigates culture-specific modifications. Designing a school to be culturally compatible with just one group of students, even if it is the most numerous group, might jeopardize students of other backgrounds—that is, if schools change their instructional strategies to be compatible with students from just one ethnic group, these strategies might not work for students from other backgrounds.

Another problem with making educational choices that are solely culturally compatible is that it may lead to segregation being posited as the most effective solution to educational failure. Although segregation might sometimes be warranted, the truth is that our history has amply demonstrated that it often leads to inequality. When speaking of culturally dominated groups, “separate but equal” is rarely that; on the contrary, segregation generally means that powerless groups end up with an inferior education because they are given the fewest material and emotional resources for their education. Nevertheless, although